

Bridging the Gap: Immersive Environments for Resettlement

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1 IMMERSIVE ENVIRONMENTS FOR RESETTLEMENT SERVICES

In its 4th year of development, the collaboration between IRC Salt Lake City (SLC) and the University of Utah's College of Architecture and Planning has shifted the lens in the way new arrivals interact with the city. This collective, collaborative, and multi-layered initiative integrates technology and design through a co-creative

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process to address needs faced along the resettlement journey with refugees and New Americans at the center. Specifically, the need for more innovative, digital inclusive learning spaces for Refugees and New Americans (R&NAs) to facilitate engagement and exposure to emerging technology. This has included approaches to the gamification of public space and sonic interventions in virtual reality (VR) to increase digital literacy and a sense of belonging to their new communities.

2 VIRTUAL PUBLIC SPACES

The idea of using VR modules in resettlement programming emerged during the technological accelerant of COVID-19, and the arrival of a record number of Afghan parolees to SLC through the Operation Allies Welcome emergency response in the fall of 2021. The team worked with a community group of Afghans to help implement VR modules in the IRC Salt Lake City's office's Youth Education monthly Cultural Orientation trainings. VR programming is now fully integrated into IRC SLC's monthly cultural orientation training for all new arrivals via a suite of 360 VR modules that consist of a suite of 360° VR modules that include walkthroughs of U.S. schools, doctor's offices, pharmacies, public transportation, and

grocery stores that were created to specifically fit the needs of IRC SLC clients. All modules are shared via virtual public access channels to increase accessibility. Access existing 360° videos from the International Rescue Committee (IRC):

- Navigating the First Day of High School (IRC Salt Lake City 2023)
- Going to a Pharmacy (IRC Salt Lake City 2022)
- Clinic Check-In (IRC Salt Lake City 2022)
- Navigating the Front Desk at a Public School (IRC Salt Lake City 2021)
- Taking a School Bus (IRC Salt Lake City 2021)
- Enjoying a Local Tea Shop (IRC Missoula 2023)

New arrivals use Meta Quest headsets acquired via a University of Utah grant.

3 CO-CREATION

The process of creating the VR modules was informed by field research using a co-creative model between paid former refugees hired as research affiliates and design students at the University of Utah that puts clients at the center of the design process. It enables more innovative products and inclusive programs that do not have a single “owner.” These groups worked to identify needs in the resettlement process and developed designs through technology to address personal needs, including 360 VR modules and other physical and digital prototypes.

4 DATA

The IRC in Salt Lake City and University of Utah has collected client feedback data from more than 140 clients who have experienced VR. Of the group surveyed, clients spent an average of 6.8 minutes inside VR. During that time, they rated their comfort level (1 being not comfortable and 5 being very comfortable) at an average of 4 in a headset and 4.16 inside a headset immersed in a 360° video. The survey results also showed 60% of clients indicated they could imagine using VR in their homes, and 79 were able to describe the types of 360° videos they would like to see in the future. VR creates a space where newly arrived refugees can learn at their own pace and context, be immersed in new environments, and create new cognitive frames for information. In addition, engagement with technology simultaneously increases digital literacy without academic or job-related pressures and exposure to emerging technology that can create interest in future tech careers and higher education opportunities.

5 KEY PARTNERSHIPS

This initiative has been led by Professor Mozari, an Assistant Professor of Multi-Disciplinary and Design at the University of Utah and Krysti Neller-moe, Training Officer, Emerging Technologies on Switchboard, and former Education Program Manager in the IRC Salt Lake City office. Also includes the co-creative team of former refugees hired by the University of Utah as research affiliates, university design students, and IRC staff who facilitated VR workshops, supported 360° film shoots, and hosted events with newly arrived IRC clients.

6 SCALE AND REACH

The partnership has expanded and it now fully working with Switchboard, a resource hub implemented by the International Rescue Committee (IRC) that provides comprehensive support and guidance to professionals and organizations involved in refugee resettlement. This new partnership will enable the new Emerging Technologies team to scale and expand reach via technical and training assistance to resettlement service providers across the county. This will include the generation of new tech and prototypes, the integration of VR across resettlement agencies nationally, and more refugee and New American’s exposure to emerging tech.